

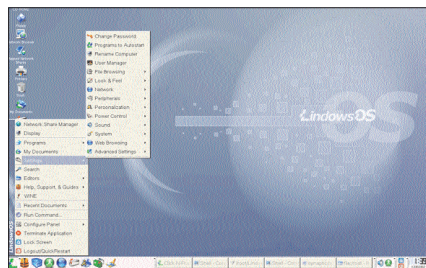
respective desktops.

The Launch menu is very user-friendly, and very similar to the Windows Start menu. All the applications are neatly classified and arranged under specific categories. Also, The quick start guide gives a comprehensive list of all the topics that might be of interest to the novice user.

However, The per-seat license can get a bit heavy on the pocket. Moreover, while the Crossover office is a useful tool for individuals keen on using MS Office tools on Linux, it would have been cheaper if Xandros had bundled a cheaper emulator.

Lindows 3.0: Linux with Windows licensing

Lindows 3.0 has a very simple installation procedure and is also one of the fastest installations; it barely took 5 minutes to install all the packages. This sounds



really impressive till you actually boot for the first time and realise that hardly any applications have been installed. This is primarily because of the Click-n-Run interface for installing and updating applications. The disk partitioning utility of Lindows is very easy to use and takes a different approach to all the other Linux distributions. It does not display the partitions using the standard Linux convention of hda1, hda2, etc. Instead it uses a very simple listing of all the primary, extended and logical partitions. This ensures that you are able to get around with partitioning even if you are not aware of Linux partition naming conventions.

Lindows provides all the fancies that are required to attract a Windows user. However, what really gets on your nerves is the limited number of applications that come along with the installation CD. Even basic office utilities such as spreadsheet viewers and presentation tools are not included in the basic installation. The Click-n-Run Express install CD promises to reduce the download time of all the applications from the Click-n-Run warehouse located at the Lindows Web site. This express CD installs many of the

Gaming in Linux

Unfortunately, the term 'Linux Gaming' has come to symbolise the ultimate oxymoron. Linux has always been considered the preserve of geeks, and geeks don't play games—they program like there's no tomorrow.

There has always been somewhat of a vicious circle revolving around Linux. Game developers have consciously steered away from porting Windows games to this platform since they don't perceive a market here.

However, few companies have tried to break this barrier. id Software released Linux versions for all of its recent games—The *Quake* franchise, and *Return To Castle Wolfenstein*. Another major development is the release of *Unreal Tournament 2003*, by Epic Games. Apart from these, there are games that come shipped with the Linux distros.

The two most popular arcade games that are included with Red Hat are *Chromium*, and *Tux Racer*. *Chromium* is a souped up version of *Space Invaders*, and involves blasting anything you come across to smithereens while flying your spaceship around, advancing to the next level, and repeating the procedure ad nauseum, ad infinitum. *Tux Racer* is slightly different in its approach. You basically control the Linux Penguin, and help it skate across an ice floor, looking for fish to eat, while avoiding obstacles. However, the game runs very slowly, even on a high-end system with a top-end graphics card, primarily because the drivers haven't been installed properly. You can also try out the free multiplayer 3D games, found at www.sourceforge.net or www.rpmfind.net. Good hunting!

libraries that are needed for the applications to install properly.

The concept of downloading applications from a central repository might not be feasible for a home user as the time required is mind boggling. For example, the average download time for StarOffice 6.0 listed at the Lindows site is seven and a half hours on a 56 Kbps modem, about an hour for a DSL modem, and 20 minutes for a T1 connection.

But before corporations with T1 lines think that it is feasible, we caution you about some licensing policies. The license for the Click-and-Run Warehouse is separate from that for the operating system and needs to be renewed every year. Moreover, a full membership of the warehouse (whatever that means), comes at an extra price. This feature can be easily bypassed by using the 'apt-get' installer that comes along with Debian Linux as Lindows is based on the Debian distribution.

What it all boils down to

Before starting this comparison there was a lot of apprehension about the very concept of comparing Linux distros that are touted as Windows replacements. "Isn't that a cheap marketing gimmick?", we were asked; and we didn't have an answer, then. But now, after completing the comparison, we have an answer—no it is not a marketing gimmick. The vendors responsible for developing these distributions have gone to great extents to make their offerings as user-friendly as possible, while retaining

the basic power and uniqueness of Linux.

In terms of Windows look-n-feel, usability and user friendliness, Xandros was slightly better than ELX Power Desktop 2.0. However, Xandros has complex licensing issues, and has to be bought, even for home use—it has a per seat or per user licensing policy. ELX, however, is free to download for home and educational use. Thus, from the economic point of view ELX beats Xandros.

In spite of all these features there are a few troublesome areas that have to be addressed, such as hardware compatibility. Another area that looks worrying is the pricing and the licensing policies. In particular installing applications on Xandros and Lindows can be bypassed by using the freely available tools from the Debian Linux distribution, which effectively means that they don't have to pay for the support provided by the respective vendors. This is also true for ELX. Apart from these annoyances all the Windows look-alike distributions gave good overall results.

Desktop Linux comparison

Red Hat Linux 9.0: Old wine in a new bottle

Red Hat is probably the most recognised of all the Linux distributions. It has been installed in almost every thinkable form, from servers to clusters. But how suitable is it for the desktop? Of late, Red Hat is attempting to become more